

foundation, Kolkata, a direct descendant of Nawab Wajid Ali Shah, writing to the Uttar Pradesh Tourism Department, saying, "His (Jafar Mir's) roots go back to a family in Patna. It is amusing that he claims to be from a line of rulers of Oudh and has declared himself the Nawab of Sheesh Mahal. In a patriarchal society this can't be true."

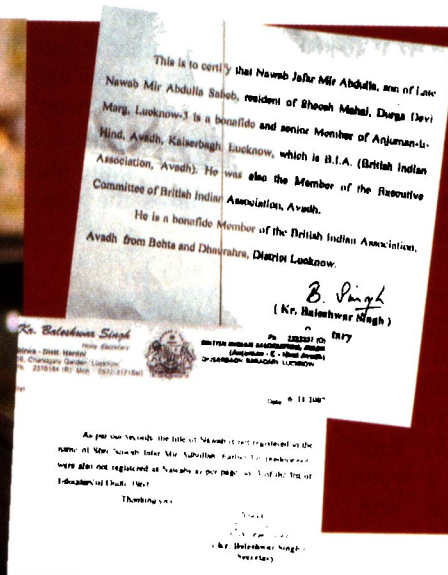
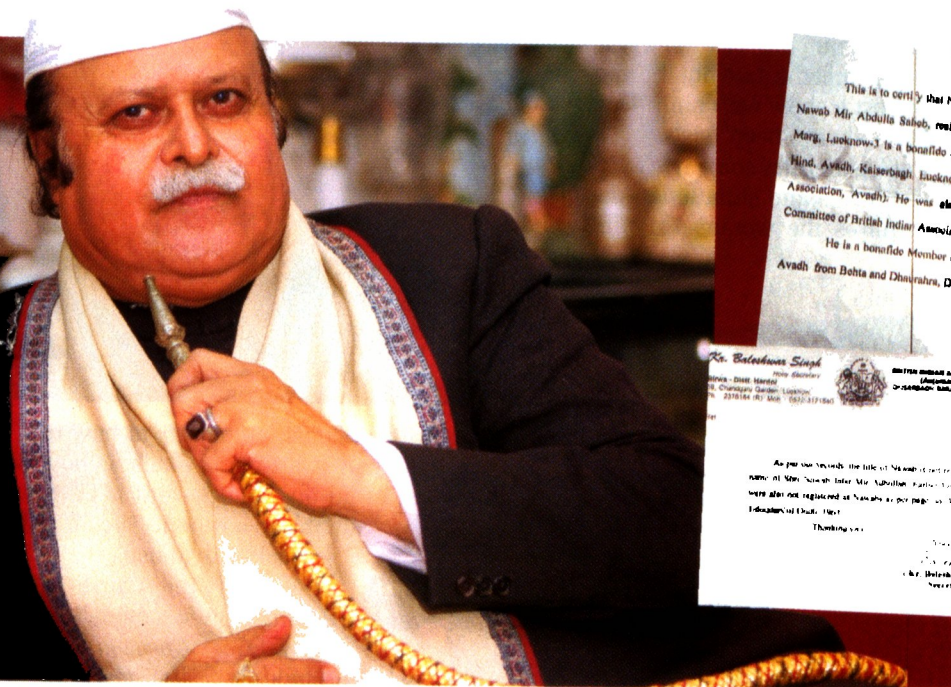
Jafar Mir counters this by saying though his paternal roots are from Patna nobility, they moved back to Awadh in 1917.

the Awadh royalty. Later, to maintain his royal links with Sheeh Mahal, he got 'Shishmahal' registered as his family title. Hence, the two warring families are identified as Nawabeen-e-Sheesh Mahal and Nawab Shishmahal.

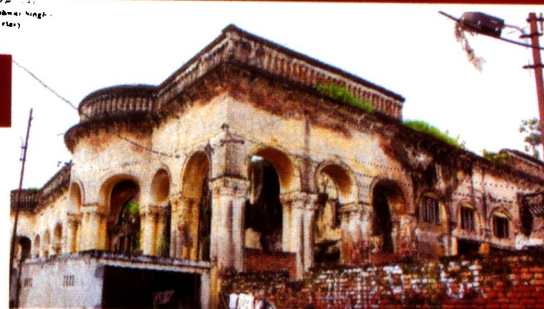
The RFA goes on to blame Jafar Mir for organising royal dinners and mujras for foreigners, charging \$650 (Rs 27,450) per head for dinner and \$1,000 (Rs 42,000) each for dinner with mujra. Jafar Mir rubbishes these allegations. "I organised a feast only once for foreign tourists at the request of a

Mir's father was a well-known antique dealer of Lucknow who left behind a vast collection of antiques. Ibrahim Ali also claims that Jafar Mir was working as an area manager of a pharmaceutical company. He resigned from his job in 1995 and took charge of his father's business and became a "nawab".

To add fuel to the royal fire, Jafar Mir claims some of the RFA's members are "dubious characters". "I was made vice-president but resigned as I was suspicious of the activities of some of its members," he says.



SEALS OF DOUBT: The RFA logo; two contradictory BIA certificates indicate Jafar Mir is a nawab (top) and not; the royal residence Sheesh Mahal (below)



"As my maternal side was also nobility, I have inherited the title of Nawab of Sheesh Mahal from my mother. Being a blueblood royal from the direct lineage of Wajid Ali Shah, Mohammad Ali Shah and Asif-ud Daulah from my maternal side, I am within my rights to refer to myself as a nawab." He produces records to prove that his grandfather Syed Wajid Hussain was the son of Syed Lutf Ali Khan, whose mother, Razia Begum, was the daughter of Nawab Syed Mohammad.

The truth is that the battle of the nawabs is between two parallel families with connections to the family of Awadh. Ibrahim Ali's grandfather, Sadiq Ali, moved to Barabanki. A separate palace called Sadiq Mahal was constructed after he was 'ousted' from Sheesh Mahal, the traditional abode of

British historian to promote our culture and history. For which, the charge was Rs 1,000 per head," he says.

To add to the intrigue, Kunwar Baleshwar Singh, secretary of the British Indian Association of Awadh (BIA), which maintains the record of all taluqdars and nawabs, has issued contradictory certificates. One states that the title of 'Nawab' is not registered in the name of Jafar Mir Abdullah or his predecessors (only two nawabs including Ibrahim Shishmahal are registered with BIA). Singh told INDIA TODAY that neither is Jafar Mir nor were his ancestors nawabs. On the other hand, Singh had issued another certificate declaring Jafar Mir to be a nawab and affirmed he was a bona fide member of the BIA.

The royal intrigue turns murkier with Ibrahim Ali claiming that Jafar

In the royal battle against the impostors, no one has come out a winner yet. However, this war has opened a can of royal worms, reminiscent of the famous scene in Satyajit Ray's version of *Shatranj ke Khiladi* where the two aristocrats, Mir and Mirza, try to checkmate each other on the chess board while Wajid Ali Shah, the nawab, is being taken into custody. In the film, Mirza exclaims, "No one's fortune is the same throughout his life. What a pitiful situation it is." Mir responds, "Please save your own king first and mourn for the nawab later." In Lucknow these days, life is imitating art.